

Board 1

South Deals

None Vul

♠ A 7 2
♥ Q J 10 8
♦ 9 5
♣ K J 9 3

♠ K Q 3

♥ 9 6 4

♦ A Q 7 3

♣ 6 4 2

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ J 10 9 5

♥ 7 5 2

♦ 8 6 4

♣ Q 10 5

♠ 8 6 4

♥ A K 3

♦ K J 10 2

♣ A 8 7

<i>West</i>	<i>North</i>	<i>East</i>	<i>South</i>
			1NT

Pass 3NT

All Pass

3NT by South

Lead: ♥Q

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♥Q, dummy plays the ♥4 and East the ♥2.

Winners: ♠=0 ♥=2 ♦=4 ♣=1 Total = 7

Needing two more winners you will have to make both the ♠K and ♠Q. This will only be possible if West holds the ♠A. Win the first trick (if you don't West might switch to ♣s).

West plays low.

A small ♠ toward dummy's honours, and it holds the trick.

You should take your four ♦ winners now, being sure to end up in your hand.

West plays low again.

Another small ♠ toward dummy's remaining honour. This also wins.

You have now won 7 tricks so don't mess around now. Take your two Aces and let them have the last four tricks.

If East held the ♠A you would not have made the contract.

A Simple Finesse has only a 50% success rate. That's why we only take finesses as a last resort.

Board 2

North Deals

None Vul

♠ 10 4 3

♥ 9 8 2

♦ K J 6 3

♣ J 9 7

♠ 9 8 6

♥ A K Q J 4

♦ A 7 4

♣ A 2



♠ K J 5 2

♥ 7 5 3

♦ Q 10

♣ K Q 10 5

♠ A Q 7

♥ 10 6

♦ 9 8 5 2

♣ 8 6 4 3

West

North

East

South

Pass

1♥

Pass

1NT

All Pass

3NT by South

Lead: ♦ 3

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♦ 3.

East plays the ♦ 10 and you the ♦ 2.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=5 ♦=1 ♣=1 Total = 8

You need just one more winner. Since West probably has 4 ♦s you will not be able to establish a trick in that suit, so your only hope is the ♠Q. You win the first ♦ so they don't get a chance to switch to ♣s, a suit you are worse off in. Then take your 5 ♥ tricks, ending in dummy.

You can't put it off any longer.

East plays low.

A small ♠ from dummy, putting the ♠Q on. If it wins you will make your contract, if it loses you won't.

East held the ♠K so you were lucky this time.

But remember, finesses only work half the time. The other half they lose.

Board 3

North Deals

None Vul

♠ A 10 7
 ♥ Q J 10 9
 ♦ J 7 4
 ♣ 10 6 3

♠ 6 5 3

♥ 8 6 4 2

♦ K 6

♣ K J 5 2

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ Q J 9 4

♥ 7 5 3

♦ Q 10 9 2

♣ 9 4

♠ K 8 2

♥ A K

♦ A 8 5 3

♣ A Q 8 7

West	North	East	South
	Pass	Pass	2NT
Pass	3♣	Pass	3♦
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			
3NT by South			
Lead: ♥Q			

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♥Q, dummy plays the ♥2 and East the ♥3.

Winners: ♠=0 ♥=2 ♦=2 ♣=4 Total = 8

Needing one more winner you should see right away that it cannot come from ♥s, ♦s, or ♣s. That means you must hope that East has the ♠A. Win the first ♥, then play your 4 ♣ winners ending in dummy.

The moment of truth.

East plays low.

A small ♠ from dummy, and the ♠K when East plays low.

Unfortunately West takes your ♠K with the ♠A. He then plays another ♥ and you at least make 8 tricks but have no hope for a ninth one so you go down 1.

You probably thought since these Deals were all about finesses that they would work all of the time.

Welcome to the real world.

Board 4

South Deals

None Vul

♠ K Q 9 3

♥ 10

♦ K 10 6 5

♣ 10 7 3 2

♠ 8 6 2

♥ 8 4 3 2

♦ A Q 7 4

♣ 9 5



♠ J 10 5

♥ A 6

♦ J 9 3 2

♣ A 8 6 4

♠ A 7 4

♥ K Q J 9 7 5

♦ 8

♣ K Q J

West	North	East	South
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Pass

2♥

Pass

1♥

All Pass

4♥

4♥ by South

Lead: ♠K

South is to play 4♥. West leads the ♠K, dummy plays the ♠2 and East the ♠5.

Losers: ♠=2 ♥=1 ♦=0 ♣=1 Total = 4

West found the best opening lead for his side, exposing your ♠ losers before you could establish the ♣ suit for a discard. If you start to pull trumps right away the defense will grab the ♥A, then take their two ♠ tricks and you will still have the ♣A that you cannot avoid.

Other than the ♦A the only useful card in dummy is the ♦Q so you must try to make a winner out of that for a discard.

You won the ♠A.

West plays low.

Win the ♠A, lead your singleton ♦ and finesse the ♦Q. Your luck has returned, the ♦Q wins.

Dummy leads the ♦A and East follows.

You discard one of your ♠ losers on the ♦A.

At this point you have not lost any tricks, and you can see that you have only 3 losers remaining in your hand. So you start pulling trumps and establishing the ♣s.

If the ♦ finesse had lost you would have gone down 2 instead of just one.

The risk was worthwhile though since it gave you your only chance of making the contract.

Board 5

North Deals

None Vul

♠ 10 8 7 3

♥ K 8 3

♦ 6 2

♣ Q 9 6 4

♠ A Q J 2

♥ 9 7 6

♦ A K 5

♣ A J 10



♠ 6 4

♥ J 10 5 4

♦ 9 4 3

♣ K 7 5 2

♠ K 9 5

♥ A Q 2

♦ Q J 10 8 7

♣ 8 3

West

North

East

South

1 ♣

Pass

2NT

Pass

6NT

All Pass

6NT by South

Lead: ♠ 3

South is to play 6NT. West leads the ♠ 3.

Winners: ♠=4 ♥=1 ♦=5 ♣=1 Total = 11

You need one more winner from the ♥ or ♣ suit.

The straight finesse of the ♥K offers a 50% chance of success. The double finesse of the ♣ K Q offers a 75% chance of success. It's a no-brainer. Run 4 ♠s and 5 ♦s ending in your hand. Be very careful not to discard a ♣ from your hand.

You have run the ♠s and ♦s and are in your hand.

West plays low.

A small ♣, playing the ♣10 when West plays low: the first of your two ♣ finesses. Let's say East wins the ♣K and returns a ♥.

East returns the ♥J.

DO NOT FINESSE THE ♥. Stick with your original 75% plan. Take the ♥A and play your small ♣, finessing the ♣J. This is why you couldn't discard a ♣ earlier.

The single ♥ finesse is an inferior play because its success depends on East holding a specific card, the ♥K.

The double ♣ finesse is much better because its success depends on West holding either of two cards, the ♣Q **OR** the ♣K.

Board 6

South Deals

None Vul

♠ 6 5
♥ 10 8 3
♦ K Q J 10 7
♣ 8 4 2

♠ 4 3

♥ 7 5 2

♦ A 6 5 3

♣ J 10 9 5

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ K 7 2

♥ K 9 6 4

♦ 9 2

♣ K 7 6 3

♠ A Q J 10 9 8

♥ A Q J

♦ 8 4

♣ A Q

<i>West</i>	<i>North</i>	<i>East</i>	<i>South</i>
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Pass

2♦

Pass

2♣

Pass

2NT

Pass

4♠

All Pass

4♠ by South

Lead: ♦K

East plays low.

At first you might think it makes no difference but, in fact, there is only one reasonable choice. If you finesse the ♠K successfully you may still have a ♠ loser. If you finesse the ♥K successfully you will surely still have a ♥ loser. But if you finesse the ♣K successfully you will eliminate your ♣ loser.

What a great layout! Three possible finesses and every one of them would work.

But as you can see, only the ♣ finesse will actually save you a trick.

South is to play 4♠. West leads the ♦K.

East plays the ♦2 and you the ♦4.

Losers: ♠=1 ♥=1 ♦=1 ♣=1 Total = 4

West has made another great lead. Any other suit would have given you a free finesse. You should duck the first ♦. It is very possible that West has led from ♦K Q 10 and will be afraid to continue for fear you have the ♦J in your hand. You'd be very happy to see him switch to any other suit. But he doesn't.

West continues with the ♦Q.

You take it with dummy's ♦A.

You are in dummy for the first, last, and only time. You need to try a finesse right now, but which one?